How to Run Claude Code for Free

Seven steps to replace a $200 a month subscription with free open models. Setup takes under 5 minutes.

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Step 01

Get the GitHub repo

The whole project is open source on GitHub. Star it, read the docs, or fork it. Repo: github.com/Alishahryar1/free-claude-code

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Step 02

Install Free Claude Code

Open your terminal and run the install command for your operating system. This installs Claude Code, the uv package manager, Python 3.14, and the Free Claude Code proxy.

MAC / LINUX

```
curl -fsSL "https://github.com/Alishahryar1/free-claude-code/blob/main/scripts/install.sh?raw=1" | sh
```

WINDOWS POWERSHELL

```
irm "https://github.com/Alishahryar1/free-claude-code/blob/main/scripts/install.ps1?raw=1" | iex
```

Step 03

Start the proxy server

Run the proxy server. It will print an Admin UI link in the terminal that you can open in your browser.

```
fcc-server
```

Step 04

Get a free API key

Pick one provider and grab a free key. NVIDIA NIM is the default and works out of the box. OpenRouter gives you access to free DeepSeek, Kimi, and GLM models.

NVIDIA NIM: build.nvidia.com/settings/api-keys

OpenRouter: openrouter.ai/keys

Step 05

Paste your key into the Admin UI

Open the Admin UI link from your terminal. Paste your API key into the matching field (NVIDIA_NIM_API_KEY or OPENROUTER_API_KEY). Click Validate, then Apply.

> Pro tip: The default model is already set to NVIDIA's Nemotron 120B. You can change it later from the same screen.

Step 06

Launch Claude Code

Open a new terminal window and run the launcher. It reads your proxy config automatically and starts Claude Code pointed at your free provider.

```
fcc-claude
```

Step 07

Optional. Run it offline

If your machine has a decent GPU you can skip cloud providers entirely. Install Ollama, pull a model, and route Claude Code through it locally. Zero API calls. Zero cost.

```
ollama pull llama3.1 ollama serve
```

> Pro tip: Set your MODEL in the Admin UI to ollama/llama3.1 and you are running fully offline.

Step 08

Optional. Mix models by tier

Set different providers for Opus, Sonnet, and Haiku tiers inside the Admin UI. Route the heavy work to Kimi, the fast work to GLM, and keep a local fallback. All controlled from one screen.
